American-built M24 tanks at Dhaka's crowded Hindu bazaar, opening fire on sleeping students in Dhaka University's dormitories. As Zulfi Bhutto stepped out of his plane in Karachi the next morning, he was asked by airport reporters welcoming him home what the results of his talks with Mujib had been. "By the grace of God, Pakistan has been saved," Bhutto replied.

But back in Dhaka, West Pakistani troops kept firing, and then surrounded Mujib's house, arresting him. That Dhaka massacre triggered an exodus of ten million Hindus, fleeing by every river and mud road to India's border, to refugee camps set up all around Calcutta, soon threatening to choke the very air out of that great city. The events of late March 1971 augured the birth of independent Bangladesh as a nation, reincarnated from the corpse of East Pakistan.[2]

"Dear Sisters and Brothers," began the message Mujib left his people, which was read aloud in every mango grove and village throughout Bangladesh. "You are citizens of a free country. . . . West Pakistan's military force is engaged in a genocide in Bangla Desh. . . . Allah is with us. The world public opinion is with us. *Jai Bangla!* [Victory to Bengal!]"

Shastri's death in Tashkent in 1966 had brought Nehru's daughter, Indira Gandhi, to the helm in New Delhi. Nehru had long groomed her to be prime minister, appointing her India's official national hostess and taking her with him whenever he traveled abroad to foreign capitals. Though her Parsi husband, Firoze Gandhi, was unrelated to Mahatma Gandhi, millions of Indian peasants believed that Indira Gandhi was the Mahatma's daughter, not Nehru's, adding to her uniquely popular voter appeal. Like her father, she was a socialist and a born politician, and she took a keen interest in Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, more aware of his Awami League's appeal throughout East Pakistan than most West Pakistani political leaders ever were. She also understood how easy it was for President Nixon and his alter ego, Henry Kissinger, to manipulate men like Yahya Khan and Zulfi Bhutto. How oddly fortuitous it now seemed to her that Bangladesh should suddenly become so ripe for plucking away from the clasp of the military tyrants of West Pakistan, who had tried to steal Kashmir from India little more than half a decade earlier.

Indira understood Bengali, having studied music and other arts at Rabindranath Tagore's rural Shantiniketan College, north of Calcutta. She could speak with Mujib in his own language, which brought them